

CITL Quickstart: First Custom Modelfile

Scan-friendly setup guide | Goal: get your first custom model running in under 20 minutes

What You Will Finish

- Create a new Modelfile with your own bot name + system prompt.
- Build a local custom model in Ollama from a base model.
- Set that model as operational in the CITL app.
- Run one verification question to confirm it works.

Success looks like: your model appears in Ollama: List and answers in the Factbook tab without errors.

Ultra-Short Checklist (Do This First)

Ollama is installed and running. CITL app opens to the 4-tab interface. You can open the **Library / Models** tab. You know which base model to use (recommended: olmo2:13b if available).

Step-by-Step (Main Path)

Start Ollama and launch CITL	2 min
------------------------------	-------

Do

- Start Ollama service.
- Launch CITL via your normal launcher (for example RUN_FACTBOOK.sh on Ubuntu).

Expect

- App opens with tabs: Factbook, Audio / Transcribe, Translate, Library / Models.

- No immediate \"ollama not found\" error.

Quick check command:

ollama list

Open Library / Models and choose base model 2 min

- Go to **Library / Models** tab.
- Click **Refresh Models** (on Factbook tab if needed).
- In **Base model (FROM)**, pick your base (example: olmo2:13b).

If base model is missing, click **Ollama: Pull FROM** before continuing.

Fill the model form correctly 3 min

Field	What to enter	Example
Bot name	Display label for your assistant.	CITL Policy Coach
CITL-COLOR	Theme profile (optional, visual only).	soft_midnight
CITL-LANG	Default language code.	en
Base model (FROM)	The model your custom model inherits from.	olmo2:13b
New model name	Unique local model name (no spaces recommended).	citl-policycoach-v1
SYSTEM prompt	Behavior rules for your assistant.	See template below

Keep model names lowercase with dashes, e.g. citl-xyz-v1.

Write Modelfile	1 min
-----------------	-------

- Click **Write Modelfile**.
- Watch the model log panel for confirmation.

Expected log lines include:

```
Wrote Modelfile: .../Modelfile.citl-policycoach-v1
```

```
[SAVE] FROM=olmo2:13b MODEL=citl-policycoach-v1
```

Create the custom model in Ollama	4-8 min
-----------------------------------	---------

- Click **Ollama: Create/Update**.
- Wait for completion in the same log pane.

Ollama execution flow

1 Build from your Modelfile and wait for completion.

2 Confirm the model appears in ollama list.

3 Verify details with ollama show <model>:latest.

```
ollama create citl-policycoach-v1 -f ~/CITL_Modelfiles/Modelfile.citl-policycoach-v1
```

```
ollama list
```

```
ollama show citl-policycoach-v1:latest
```

Expected log progression

[CREATE] model=citl-policycoach-v1 modelfile=...

[VERIFY] Graft saved and available: citl-policycoach-v1:latest

If it stalls Run **Ollama: List** and confirm whether model appears.

Set as operational and test 2 min

- Click **Set As Operational** (or select model in Operational model dropdown).
- Go to **Factbook** tab.
- Ask a simple question and submit **Ask Factbook**.

Success: response returns and no "\"model not installed\" error appears.

SYSTEM Prompt Starter (Copy/Edit)

You are CITL Assistant, a professional academic support and fact-checking assistant.

Operational rules:

1. Use only verified information from supplied local context.
2. If context is weak or missing, say you do not have enough verified context.
3. Do not invent facts, names, dates, or citations.
4. Keep answers concise and structured.
5. Include source identifiers when available.

Quick Troubleshooting (Fast Fixes)

Symptom	Likely Cause	Fix
"ollama not found in PATH"	Ollama CLI not available in current shell/OS path.	Install Ollama or reopen terminal/session so ollama is in

Symptom	Likely Cause	Fix
		PATH.
"Base model is empty"	No FROM model selected.	Select Base model (FROM) , then run Ollama: Pull FROM .
Create works but model not selectable	Model list not refreshed yet.	Click Refresh Models and then reselect model.
Model builds but answers look generic	SYSTEM prompt too weak or missing.	Edit SYSTEM prompt, click Write Modelfile , then Create/Update .
Wrong output source behavior	Old model still operational.	Set new model as operational and retry.

If answers show cross-entity contamination or no citations in reliability modes, treat as release blocker and escalate.

Terminal Fallback (If GUI Is Unavailable)

```
# 1) Pull base model (if needed)

ollama pull olmo2:13b


# 2) Create your Modelfile

cat > ~/CITL_Modelfiles/Modelfile.citl-policycoach-v1 <<'EOF'

FROM olmo2:13b

SYSTEM ""

You are CITL Policy Coach...

""

EOF
```

3) Build custom model

```
ollama create citl-policycoach-v1 -f ~/CITL_Modelfiles/Modelfile.citl-policycoach-v1
```

4) Verify

```
ollama list
```

```
ollama show citl-policycoach-v1:latest
```

Final 60-Second Validation

My model appears in ollama list. I selected it as Operational model in CITL. Factbook tab answered one test question using this model. I saved the model name and base model in team notes.

Document owner: CITL Engineering. Recommended usage: onboarding, lab setup, and handoff to instructional technologists.